THE UNIVERSITY CITY COMPASS

18 Student Cities · Measured Against Your Top 10 Priorities

From Kuala Lumpur to Rabat — where each city stands on quality education, affordability, safety, growth, horizons, experience, independence, career readiness, community and lifelong opportunity. The goal: become capable, thoughtful, and adaptable — ready for life, not just a job, while helping others succeed.

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How to Read This Report

Each of the 18 cities is profiled individually against your ten priorities. Every priority receives a score from 1 to 5 and a short note explaining it. The scale is qualitative: **5 = outstanding**, **4 = strong**, **3 = adequate**, **2 = limited**, **1 = weak**.

Scores are indicative judgements, not measurements. They are anchored to current public data — the QS World University Rankings 2026 and 2027[1][2], the QS Arab Region Rankings 2026[3], and the U.S. News Best Global Universities 2026 edition[4] — combined with typical tuition levels, cost of living, safety conditions and the practical realities of student life in each city as of November 2026. Different students weigh these priorities differently; use the notes, not the numbers alone.

As requested, this report contains **no overall ranking**. Cities appear in the order you listed them, and the summary matrix at the end shows scores side by side without totals, averages or ranks.

The ten priorities, as you defined them

Priority	What it asks
Quality Education	Strong universities, teaching and research that truly develop the mind.
Affordability	Tuition and living costs a student can realistically sustain.
Safety & Convenience	A secure, liveable city where daily life is easy.
Personal Development	Room to grow in character, confidence and maturity.
Broader Horizons	Exposure to new cultures, ideas and ways of seeing the world.
Experience & Wisdom	Learning from life, history and people — not only lectures.
Independence & Adaptability	The chance to live independently and adapt to new environments.
Practical & Career Readiness	Skills, internships and pathways that prepare for real work.
Collaboration & Community	Teamwork, friendships and a supportive student community.
Lifelong Opportunities	Networks, alumni and foundations for a meaningful long-term life.

City Profiles

Each profile lists the city's universities, a one-line character sketch, and a score with a short note for every one of the ten priorities.

Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

Universities: Universiti Malaya (UM)

Southeast Asia's most complete student package: a world top-60 university, English-medium teaching, and one of the lowest costs of any ranked university city.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**5 / 5**	UM is 58th in QS WUR 2026 and 56th in 2027 — Malaysia's flagship with top-100 subjects across engineering, computer science and business.[1][2]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Public tuition a few thousand USD per year; comfortable student life on roughly USD 500–800 a month.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	Generally safe with good metro links; routine big-city caution against petty theft.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	Active campus clubs, leadership programmes and a lively student-city scene.
Broader Horizons	**5 / 5**	Malay, Chinese and Indian cultures meet in one English-speaking, Muslim-majority metropolis.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	ASEAN's business hub gives real industry exposure alongside study.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Easy independent living, friendly student visas, halal food everywhere.
Practical & Career Readiness	**5 / 5**	Strong regional job market in finance, tech and energy; degrees well recognised across Asia.
Collaboration & Community	**5 / 5**	Tens of thousands of international students; Malaysia is a top global study destination.
Lifelong Opportunities	**5 / 5**	Post-study work options and alumni networks spanning ASEAN and the wider Muslim world.

Istanbul, Türkiye

Universities: Istanbul Technical University · Boğaziçi University · Istanbul University · Koç University · Sabancı University

Five world-ranked universities in a city that is itself an education — Europe and Asia in one skyline.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**5 / 5**	ITU (298th), Boğaziçi (371), Koç (323) and Sabancı (404) all sit in the QS WUR 2026 top tier; ITU is 91st worldwide for Engineering & Technology.[1]
Affordability	**3 / 5**	Public tuition is low, but inflation has raised living costs; private universities are costly without their generous scholarships.
Safety & Convenience	**3 / 5**	A vast, thrilling but demanding megacity — traffic, crowding and economic volatility require adjustment.
Personal Development	**5 / 5**	Unmatched cultural life: arts, debate, volunteering and student societies in a city of 16 million.
Broader Horizons	**5 / 5**	A living crossroads of civilisations; few cities widen a student's worldview faster.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	Centuries of scholarship plus a large modern industry base to learn from.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Navigating the megacity builds self-reliance quickly; some Turkish helps daily life.
Practical & Career Readiness	**4 / 5**	Türkiye's largest economy: deep internship pools in engineering, finance, media and trade.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Huge student communities and strong Erasmus and exchange links with Europe.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	Powerful alumni networks across Türkiye, Europe and the Middle East.

Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

Universities: King Saud University (KSU) · Princess Nourah bint Abdulrahman University (PNU)

The Kingdom's academic capital, riding the Vision 2030 wave of investment in education and research.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	KSU ranks 143rd in QS WUR 2026 and 4th in the QS Arab Region 2026; PNU is the world's largest women's university.[1][3]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Public university education is tuition-free, often with a monthly student stipend.
Safety & Convenience	**5 / 5**	Very low crime, orderly streets and a modernising metro system.
Personal Development	**3 / 5**	Conservative social rules are easing fast, but leisure options remain narrower than in Dubai or Doha.
Broader Horizons	**3 / 5**	More local in character than the coastal Gulf hubs — deep Saudi culture, fewer foreign residents.
Experience & Wisdom	**3 / 5**	A serious, structured study environment with growing research exposure.
Independence & Adaptability	**3 / 5**	Campus life is organised and supportive, though less free-form than Western cities.
Practical & Career Readiness	**5 / 5**	Vision 2030 megaprojects, Aramco and the banking sector create exceptional graduate demand.
Collaboration & Community	**3 / 5**	Gender-segregated campuses shape a different, though close-knit, community experience.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	Strong ladder into Gulf careers, government programmes and scholarships abroad.

Dhahran / Dammam, Saudi Arabia

Universities: King Fahd University of Petroleum & Minerals (KFUPM)

A focused science-and-engineering powerhouse beside the world's energy capital.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**5 / 5**	KFUPM is 67th in QS WUR 2026 and 1st in the QS Arab Region 2026 — elite in petroleum, chemical and electrical engineering.[1][3]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Admission typically comes with full scholarships, housing and stipends.
Safety & Convenience	**5 / 5**	A calm, very safe planned city anchored by the university and Aramco.
Personal Development	**3 / 5**	Quiet, studious atmosphere; fewer diversions than Jeddah or Riyadh.
Broader Horizons	**3 / 5**	International faculty and industry visitors, though the student mix is less cosmopolitan.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	Daily proximity to the energy industry is an education in itself.
Independence & Adaptability	**3 / 5**	Campus-centred living — comfortable but sheltered.
Practical & Career Readiness	**5 / 5**	A near-direct pipeline into Aramco, SABIC and the Gulf energy sector.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Small, tight-knit campus community with strong cohort spirit.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	Alumni lead the region's energy, engineering and technology sectors.

Ankara, Türkiye

Universities: Middle East Technical University (METU) · Bilkent University

Türkiye's top public and private universities in a calm, purpose-built student capital.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**5 / 5**	METU is 269th and Bilkent 415th in QS WUR 2026 — the country's premier public and private institutions.[1]
Affordability	**4 / 5**	Public fees are minimal and living costs sit well below Istanbul's.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	Orderly, compact and used to students; calmer than the big coastal cities.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	Strong campus culture — METU's societies and spring festivals are legendary.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	English-medium teaching at both flagships, with wide exchange networks.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	The seat of government, embassies and think-tanks offers civic and policy exposure.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	A manageable city where students quickly learn to stand on their own feet.
Practical & Career Readiness	**4 / 5**	Technoparks and the defence, aerospace and software sectors recruit heavily on campus.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Large, engaged student population with a collaborative academic culture.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	Alumni dominate Turkish engineering, academia and public life.

Doha, Qatar

Universities: Qatar University · Education City (Georgetown, Northwestern, Carnegie Mellon, Weill Cornell Medicine and more)

One city hosting a whole district of world-class branch campuses alongside the national university.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	Qatar University is 112th in QS WUR 2026 and 2nd in the Arab region; Education City brings top US campuses to one district.[1][3]
Affordability	**4 / 5**	Qatar Foundation and QU scholarships are generous; daily costs are high but often covered.
Safety & Convenience	**5 / 5**	Routinely ranked among the world's safest cities, with a clean, modern metro.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	Excellent facilities, sports and cultural institutions such as the Museum of Islamic Art.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	An expat-majority, World Cup-tested city with a genuinely global outlook.
Experience & Wisdom	**3 / 5**	Smaller local scene; the deepest experience comes through campus and internships.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Compact and easy to navigate — independent living comes naturally here.
Practical & Career Readiness	**4 / 5**	Energy, finance, aviation and sports industries offer premium internships.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Education City's inter-campus life lets students mix across universities.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	Strong routes into Gulf employers and the branch campuses' home institutions.

Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates

Universities: Khalifa University · NYU Abu Dhabi

The UAE capital pairs a rising research university with one of the world's most selective liberal-arts colleges.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	Khalifa University is 177th in QS WUR 2026 and 3rd in the Arab region; NYU Abu Dhabi admits single-digit percentages of applicants.[1][3]
Affordability	**4 / 5**	NYU Abu Dhabi meets full demonstrated need; Khalifa offers scholarships — but the city itself is expensive.
Safety & Convenience	**5 / 5**	Regularly listed among the safest cities on earth; excellent infrastructure.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	High-quality sports, arts and beach life balanced with study.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	A global hub where classmates and colleagues come from everywhere.
Experience & Wisdom	**3 / 5**	Purpose-built and polished; less organic street life than older cities.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Modern, well-organised city — independence is easy to practise.
Practical & Career Readiness	**4 / 5**	Energy, aerospace, AI and sovereign-fund employers sit on the doorstep.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	NYU Abu Dhabi's student body is famously international; Khalifa's cohort is research-driven.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	Degrees open doors across the Gulf and, via NYU, worldwide.

Penang, Malaysia

Universities: Universiti Sains Malaysia (USM)

A top-150 research university on a heritage island of street food, temples and tech factories.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	USM is joint 128th in QS WUR 2027 and holds Malaysia's APEX research status.[2]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Among the cheapest quality study destinations anywhere — low fees, low rents, inexpensive food.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	A relaxed island with low crime and easy buses and ride-hailing.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	George Town's arts scene, festivals and outdoors give a rounded student life.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	A UNESCO-listed melting pot of Malay, Chinese, Indian and Peranakan cultures.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	Living in a working heritage port teaches lessons no classroom can.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Compact, friendly and English-speaking — ideal first step abroad.
Practical & Career Readiness	**4 / 5**	Penang's electronics cluster ('Silicon Valley of the East') offers serious engineering internships.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Warm campus community with students from across Asia, Africa and the Middle East.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	A respected springboard into Malaysian, Singaporean and regional careers.

Cairo, Egypt

Universities: Cairo University · Ain Shams University

Venerable mass universities at the heart of the Arab world's cultural capital.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	Cairo University stands 363rd in QS WUR 2027 — Egypt's flagship, with medicine and engineering of long renown.[2]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Public tuition is symbolic and living costs are among the lowest of any major city.
Safety & Convenience	**3 / 5**	A chaotic, intense megacity; safe in most districts but demanding on newcomers.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	Debate, theatre, journalism and activism have shaped generations of Arab leaders.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	The cultural heart of the Arab world — media, literature and history on every corner.
Experience & Wisdom	**5 / 5**	Five millennia of civilisation outside the lecture hall; wisdom comes with the address.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Students learn resilience, negotiation and improvisation very quickly.
Practical & Career Readiness	**3 / 5**	The domestic job market is tight and salaries low; the degree outperforms the local economy.
Collaboration & Community	**5 / 5**	Hundreds of thousands of students — an unrivalled pool of peers and lifelong friends.
Lifelong Opportunities	**3 / 5**	A respected name across the Arab world, though many graduates seek work abroad.

Astana, Kazakhstan

Universities: Nazarbayev University · Astana Medical University

A young, ambitious capital whose flagship university was built with world-class partners.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	Nazarbayev University was founded with partners such as Cambridge and Duke; it is 831st in the U.S. News Best Global Universities table and climbing fast.[4]
Affordability	**4 / 5**	State grants commonly cover tuition plus a stipend; living costs are moderate.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	A planned, low-crime capital — though winters are fiercely cold.
Personal Development	**3 / 5**	Small-city calm; the social scene centres on the campus.
Broader Horizons	**3 / 5**	A young city still forming its identity; fewer established cultural institutions.
Experience & Wisdom	**3 / 5**	Modern curricula and research internships compensate for the shorter history.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	English-medium NU life pushes students toward self-direction and global habits.
Practical & Career Readiness	**4 / 5**	The government, sovereign institutions and a growing tech scene hire NU graduates first.
Collaboration & Community	**3 / 5**	Close-knit cohorts on a modern campus, but a smaller international community.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	NU alumni are fast-tracked into Kazakhstan's ministries, companies and PhD programmes abroad.

Almaty, Kazakhstan

Universities: Al-Farabi Kazakh National University (KazNU) · Kazakh National Medical University

Central Asia's leading university in its most cosmopolitan and liveable city.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	KazNU is 167th in QS WUR 2026 (177th in 2027) — the number one university in Central Asia.[1][2]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Low tuition, cheap transport and some of the region's most affordable student living.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	Relaxed, green and student-friendly, with mountains at the edge of town.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	Cafés, hiking, skiing and an active student scene shape a balanced life.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	Kazakh, Russian and international cultures meet in the region's most open city.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	A Soviet-era scientific tradition renewed with international partnerships.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Easy to live independently; Russian or Kazakh helps outside campus.
Practical & Career Readiness	**3 / 5**	The regional business hub, though graduate salaries remain modest.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Large, sociable student community with growing exchange programmes.
Lifelong Opportunities	**3 / 5**	A strong name within Central Asia; global recognition still developing.

Dubai, United Arab Emirates

Universities: Mohammed Bin Rashid University (MBRU) · Dubai Medical College · international branch campuses

A global city of branch campuses where the classroom meets the marketplace.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**3 / 5**	Branch campuses inherit their home universities' names, but local quality varies — check the parent institution's standing.[1]
Affordability	**2 / 5**	The most expensive option on this list: high tuition and high rents, with scholarships only partial.
Safety & Convenience	**5 / 5**	Exceptionally safe, with world-class transport, healthcare and services.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	Endless events, sports and networking; self-discipline is needed amid the distractions.
Broader Horizons	**5 / 5**	Over 200 nationalities in one city — a daily lesson in global citizenship.
Experience & Wisdom	**3 / 5**	Dazzling but young; depth comes from people rather than institutions.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Independent living is straightforward — if the budget allows.
Practical & Career Readiness	**5 / 5**	Unmatched internship access in trade, aviation, hospitality, media and finance.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	A highly international student body, though many commute and community can feel transient.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	A Dubai degree plus work experience is a recognised springboard across the Gulf and beyond.

Izmir, Türkiye

Universities: Izmir Institute of Technology (IZTECH) · Ege University

A liberal Aegean student city with a strong technical institute and a giant public university.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	IZTECH teaches in English and punches above its weight in science and engineering; Ege is one of Türkiye's oldest and largest universities.[1]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Low public fees and some of the cheapest student living in the country.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	Safe, seaside and famously easy-going.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	Beaches, festivals and a youthful, open atmosphere.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	Aegean history and a tolerant, outward-looking local culture.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	Archaeology, agriculture and shipping make the region an open-air classroom.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	A gentle place to learn independence — friendly and manageable.
Practical & Career Readiness	**3 / 5**	A smaller regional economy; many graduates target Istanbul, Ankara or abroad.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Tight student communities around the campus districts.
Lifelong Opportunities	**3 / 5**	Respected within Türkiye; international name recognition is modest.

Amman, Jordan

Universities: University of Jordan (UJ) · Jordan University of Science and Technology (JUST)

The Levant's safest and most welcoming student hub, drawing youth from across the Arab world.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**4 / 5**	UJ is 10th in the QS Arab Region Rankings 2026; JUST is respected across the region for engineering, medicine and pharmacy.[3]
Affordability	**4 / 5**	Moderate fees and affordable living, though Amman is pricier than Jordan's other cities.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	One of the region's safest capitals; easy buses and walkable student districts.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	NGOs, startups and refugee-response programmes offer meaningful volunteer growth.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	A crossroads of Levantine, Gulf and international students and ideas.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	Jerash, Petra and the Dead Sea turn weekends into history lessons.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Gentle landing for a first time abroad; Arabic immersion comes naturally.
Practical & Career Readiness	**3 / 5**	High youth unemployment at home pushes graduates toward the Gulf.
Collaboration & Community	**5 / 5**	A famously pan-Arab campus mix — friendships span the whole region.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	A proven pipeline into Gulf employers, UN agencies and postgraduate study abroad.

Baku, Azerbaijan

Universities: Baku State University · Azerbaijan Medical University

A Caspian oil capital modernising its universities along European lines.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**3 / 5**	Baku State is the national flagship; programmes are steadily internationalising but global ranks remain modest.[1]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Very low tuition and living costs; international medical students find it especially affordable.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	Safe streets, a clean metro and an orderly seaside boulevard.
Personal Development	**3 / 5**	Cultural life is growing, though student freedoms are more constrained than in Türkiye.
Broader Horizons	**3 / 5**	A Turkic-Persian-European crossroads, but English is limited outside campus.
Experience & Wisdom	**3 / 5**	Strong traditions in oil engineering and medicine.
Independence & Adaptability	**3 / 5**	Daily life runs in Azerbaijani or Russian — a real immersion challenge.
Practical & Career Readiness	**3 / 5**	The economy centres on energy; opportunities outside it are narrower.
Collaboration & Community	**3 / 5**	Friendly campuses with growing numbers of international, especially medical, students.
Lifelong Opportunities	**3 / 5**	Degrees serve the region well; wider mobility usually needs further study.

Alexandria, Egypt

Universities: Alexandria University

The Mediterranean's ancient city of learning, still teaching hundreds of thousands.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**3 / 5**	A large, historic public university strongest in medicine, engineering and science, with stretched resources.[1]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Symbolic public fees and seaside living at a fraction of Western costs.
Safety & Convenience	**3 / 5**	Friendlier and calmer than Cairo, but still a demanding Egyptian megacity.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	Corniche life, cafés and a storied literary heritage.
Broader Horizons	**3 / 5**	Less international today than in its cosmopolitan past, but deeply cultured.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	The city of the ancient Library — scholarly heritage on every street.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Students quickly become resourceful and self-reliant.
Practical & Career Readiness	**3 / 5**	Regional job market is limited; medicine graduates fare best.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Enormous, warm-hearted student community.
Lifelong Opportunities	**3 / 5**	A respected name in Egypt and the Arab world; many look abroad afterwards.

Tashkent, Uzbekistan

Universities: National University of Uzbekistan (NUUz) · Tashkent Pediatric Medical Institute

Central Asia's historic scholarly capital, reforming and reopening to the world.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**3 / 5**	NUUz is the national flagship; the medical institutes draw growing numbers of international students.[1]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Among the cheapest places in the world to earn a recognised degree.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	Safe, orderly and clean, with a Soviet-era metro.
Personal Development	**3 / 5**	A quieter social scene, enlivened by bazaars, parks and student theatres.
Broader Horizons	**3 / 5**	Deep Silk Road heritage, but limited everyday English and fewer foreign peers.
Experience & Wisdom	**3 / 5**	Strong schools of mathematics, oriental studies and medicine.
Independence & Adaptability	**3 / 5**	Uzbek or Russian is needed daily — immersion builds character fast.
Practical & Career Readiness	**3 / 5**	A reform-era economy opening new doors in business, IT and medicine.
Collaboration & Community	**3 / 5**	Hospitable campuses; the international community is small but growing.
Lifelong Opportunities	**3 / 5**	Best for careers in Central Asia or further study abroad.

Rabat, Morocco

Universities: Mohammed V University

A calm Atlantic capital whose flagship university anchors Morocco's ties with Africa and Europe.

Priority	Score	What it means here
Quality Education	**3 / 5**	Mohammed V University is Morocco's flagship, strongest in medicine, law and the sciences, teaching in Arabic and French.[1]
Affordability	**5 / 5**	Near-free public tuition and moderate living costs.
Safety & Convenience	**4 / 5**	One of Africa's calmest capitals; compact and walkable.
Personal Development	**4 / 5**	A gentle blend of Andalusian heritage, French influence and modern Moroccan life.
Broader Horizons	**4 / 5**	A bridge between Africa and Europe with wide Francophone networks.
Experience & Wisdom	**4 / 5**	Roman ruins, medina crafts and a living tradition of scholarship.
Independence & Adaptability	**4 / 5**	Friendly and manageable — a soft landing for life abroad; French or Arabic helps.
Practical & Career Readiness	**3 / 5**	A competitive domestic market; many careers point toward France, Canada or the Gulf.
Collaboration & Community	**4 / 5**	Welcoming campuses with students from across West and Central Africa.
Lifelong Opportunities	**4 / 5**	Strong lifelong networks across the Francophone world and the African continent.

Score Matrix — At a Glance

All scores side by side, in the order the cities were listed. No totals, averages or ranks — weigh the priorities that matter most to you.

City	Edu	Aff	Saf	Dev	Hor	Wis	Ind	Car	Com	Opp
Kuala Lumpur	5	5	4	4	5	4	4	5	5	5
Istanbul	5	3	3	5	5	4	4	4	4	4
Riyadh	4	5	5	3	3	3	3	5	3	4
Dhahran / Dammam	5	5	5	3	3	4	3	5	4	4
Ankara	5	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4
Doha	4	4	5	4	4	3	4	4	4	4
Abu Dhabi	4	4	5	4	4	3	4	4	4	4
Penang	4	5	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	4
Cairo	4	5	3	4	4	5	4	3	5	3
Astana	4	4	4	3	3	3	4	4	3	4
Almaty	4	5	4	4	4	4	4	3	4	3
Dubai	3	2	5	4	5	3	4	5	4	4
Izmir	4	5	4	4	4	4	4	3	4	3
Amman	4	4	4	4	4	4	4	3	5	4
Baku	3	5	4	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
Alexandria	3	5	3	4	3	4	4	3	4	3
Tashkent	3	5	4	3	3	3	3	3	3	3
Rabat	3	5	4	4	4	4	4	3	4	4

Edu = Quality Education · **Aff** = Affordability · **Saf** = Safety & Convenience · **Dev** = Personal Development · **Hor** = Broader Horizons · **Wis** = Experience & Wisdom · **Ind** = Independence & Adaptability · **Car** = Practical & Career Readiness · **Com** = Collaboration & Community · **Opp** = Lifelong Opportunities

Sources

[1] Quacquarelli Symonds. *QS World University Rankings 2026*. QS Quacquarelli Symonds, 2025.

[2] Quacquarelli Symonds. *QS World University Rankings 2027*. QS Quacquarelli Symonds, 2026.

[3] Quacquarelli Symonds. *QS Arab Region University Rankings 2026*. QS Quacquarelli Symonds, 2025.

[4] U.S. News & World Report. *Best Global Universities Rankings, 2026 edition*. U.S. News & World Report, 2026.

Scores for affordability, safety and the life-experience priorities reflect typical tuition levels, cost-of-living conditions and publicly reported safety information as of November 2026. They are indicative judgements intended for orientation, not precise measurement.